

Draft - expert review pending

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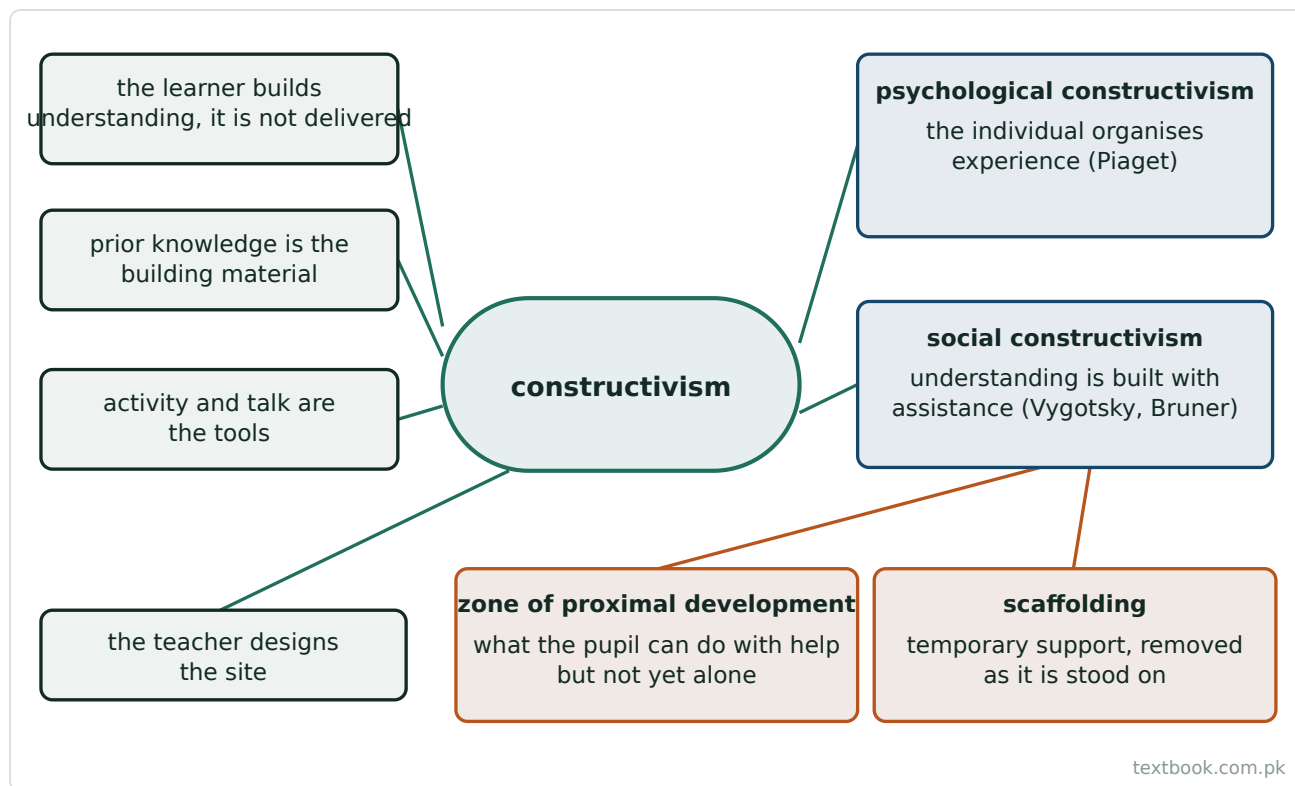
Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

Topic 3.4 - Constructivist approaches and the classroom

A real classroom situation

Mr Qasim teaches Class 5 mathematics. There is a pupil, Babar, who cannot finish the subtraction-with-borrowing worksheet alone. Left to himself, he writes anything to fill the pages. Given the answer to copy, he copies. But when Mr Qasim sits beside him for ninety seconds and says only "show me the bigger number - now, can you take this away from it?", Babar finishes four sums correctly, and by Friday he finishes two alone.

Notice what did not happen. Nobody explained borrowing better. Nobody rewarded him. The difference was ninety seconds of the right help, at the right distance - close enough to hold him up, far enough that he was still the one doing the subtracting.



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Explanation

Constructivism: the learner builds understanding

Constructivism is the perspective that learners do not receive knowledge; they **construct** it, actively, out of experience and what they already hold (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The claim sounds soft and is not. It has a hard edge: if understanding must be built by the learner, it cannot be transmitted by the teacher, however clear the explanation. The clearest lecture in Sindh still has to be rebuilt, piece by piece, inside sixty different heads, each starting from a different place.

Constructivism comes in two strengths, and the course guide's "constructivist appoes" covers both. **Psychological constructivism** (the Piaget stream, Topic 3.2) puts the construction inside the individual: the learner organises and reorganises experience. **Social constructivism** puts the construction in the assistance: learners build understanding with the help of others who know the

way (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). Babar's ninety seconds is social constructivism in operation.

The misconception to clear now. "Constructivism means the teacher stops teaching." The theory says the opposite. Because the learner must do the building, the teacher's work becomes more deliberate, not less: the site must be designed (which task, in which order), the materials supplied (which schemas will be met), and the scaffold placed and *removed* on schedule. A hands-off teacher has abandoned the site, and the abandonment is not constructivism; it is neglect with a theory attached.

Social constructivism: the zone of proximal development and scaffolding

Two ideas carry the social version into daily teaching.

The zone of proximal development. Vygotsky distinguished what a learner can do alone from what the same learner can do **with help** - and located learning in the gap between the two. Babar cannot finish the worksheet alone (outside his current independent reach) but can with one hint (inside his zone). The worksheet he cannot do even with help is outside the zone entirely; the sums he can already do alone are behind it. Teaching aims at the zone: not too hard to reach with support, not so easy that the support is decoration.

Scaffolding. Bruner's word for that support, borrowed from building: a **temporary** framework that lets a stronger structure be built within it (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The word's whole discipline is in "temporary". Mr Qasim's ninety-second prompt is a scaffold because it comes down - by Friday Babar does two sums alone. Help that never comes down is not scaffolding; it is a permanent crutch, and the pupil learns to need it.

Scaffolds have shapes a teacher can choose among: a hint rather than an answer; a worked example to follow; a sentence starter for the pupil who cannot begin; a partner who must agree; a checklist that externalises the steps. The art is matching the scaffold to the gap - and removing it, deliberately, while watching whether the structure stands.

Choosing and combining theories in real teaching

The guide's Week 7 slot is "Application activities & review", and this is it. The four families of this unit are not rivals to be ranked; they are lenses that each see something the others miss. The professional skill is the **choice**, made on evidence.

Take a scene you now know well: a pupil refuses to work. Four readings.

The **behaviourist** reading asks what the refusal gets him. If refusing work earns the teacher's full attention while working earns a tick, the refusal is being reinforced, and the response is to re-aim attention - notice the work, shrink the audience of the refusal.

The **cognitive** reading asks what the work meets in his schemas. If the worksheet assumes a step he never built, the refusal is a rational response to guaranteed failure, and the response is to find the missing step and supply it - perhaps with the roti lesson's order.

The **social learning** reading asks what he has watched happen to pupils who try and fail here. If trying visibly has cost him social standing, the response is to change what trying is seen to earn - Miss Sadia's "good try" is the tool.

The **constructivist** reading asks whether the task sits in his zone at all. If it is beyond even assisted reach, the response is a nearer task plus a scaffold, with the scaffold's removal planned.

One pupil, one behaviour, four defensible readings - and usually the truest account is a mixture. The teacher's discipline is to hold the lenses open long enough to choose, rather than to default to the first one that absolves the teaching.

theory family	what learning is	the teacher's job	what it misses
① behaviourism	change in observable behaviour	arrange consequences that train the wanted behaviour	understanding, meaning, the inside of the head
② cognitive	change in thinking, schemas rebuilt	order experience: enactive to iconic to symbolic; meet prior schemas	the social setting where learning happens
③ social learning	change through observation of models	be a deliberate model, aim attention and its outcomes	what is constructed, not just copied
④ constructivism	understanding built by the learner with assistance	design the task, place and remove scaffolds in the zone	slow, hard to run with sixty pupils and a syllabus clock

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Activity: Four lenses on one pupil

In groups of four, about 25 minutes.

Each member takes one lens (behaviourist, cognitive, social learning, constructivist) and reads the pupil below for five minutes alone, writing what their lens sees and one response it suggests.

The pupil: Amjad, Class 6, completes no written work in science. He watches the demonstrations attentively and can explain them orally. His written answers, when he produces any, are copied from a neighbour. His last three teachers have called him lazy.

Reconvene. Share the four readings. Then, together: which single response would you try first, on what evidence, and what would make you change your mind?

Check your understanding

1. State constructivism's central claim in one sentence, and the hard edge it gives the teacher. (*Understand*)
2. Define the zone of proximal development, and place three tasks in it: one Babar can do alone, one with the hint, one not even with help. (*Understand*)
3. Explain why help that never comes down is not scaffolding, with an example. (*Understand*)
4. Name two scaffold shapes and the gap each fits. (*Apply*)
5. Give the four-lens reading of Amjad: one sentence per lens, each naming its response. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Constructivism holds that understanding is built by the learner - psychologically, in the individual's organisation of experience, and socially, in the assistance of others who know the way. Vygotsky's zone of proximal development locates the teachable gap between independent and assisted performance; Bruner's scaffolding names the temporary support that must come down. The unit's four families are lenses, not rivals: each sees what the others miss, and the professional act is the choice - reading one episode through all four and justifying the response on evidence.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can state constructivism's claim and explain why it demands more of the teacher, not less.
- ☐ I can define the zone of proximal development and place real tasks inside and outside it.
- ☐ I can name scaffold shapes and say when each is removed.
- ☐ I can read one episode through all four lenses and justify a first response.

Try this at your practicum school

Choose one pupil who "cannot do the work". Find, by trying, the smallest help that lets them do it - a hint, a starter, a partner. Note exactly what the help was and what the pupil did with it, then withdraw the help next lesson and note what stands. You have just mapped a corner of one pupil's zone.

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** choosing a lens for Amjad.

Four readings of Amjad are available. Choose the one you would act on first, justify it with evidence from his description, and name what would make you switch to a second lens. Your answer must show what your chosen lens sees that the others do not, and concede honestly what it misses.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Justified choice	The chosen lens is defended with specific evidence from the description.
Lens discipline	What the lens sees is stated precisely, and its blind spot conceded. (<i>Analyze</i>)
Switch condition	The named trigger for changing lenses is observable, not a feeling.
Plain, accurate writing	Terms used correctly; no padding; within the word count.

Further reading

- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapter 2. University of Manitoba. CC BY.
<https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/educational-psychology>

- Vosniadou, S. (2001). *How children learn*. Educational Practices Series No. 7. International Academy of Education / UNESCO IBE. <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED455955>

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